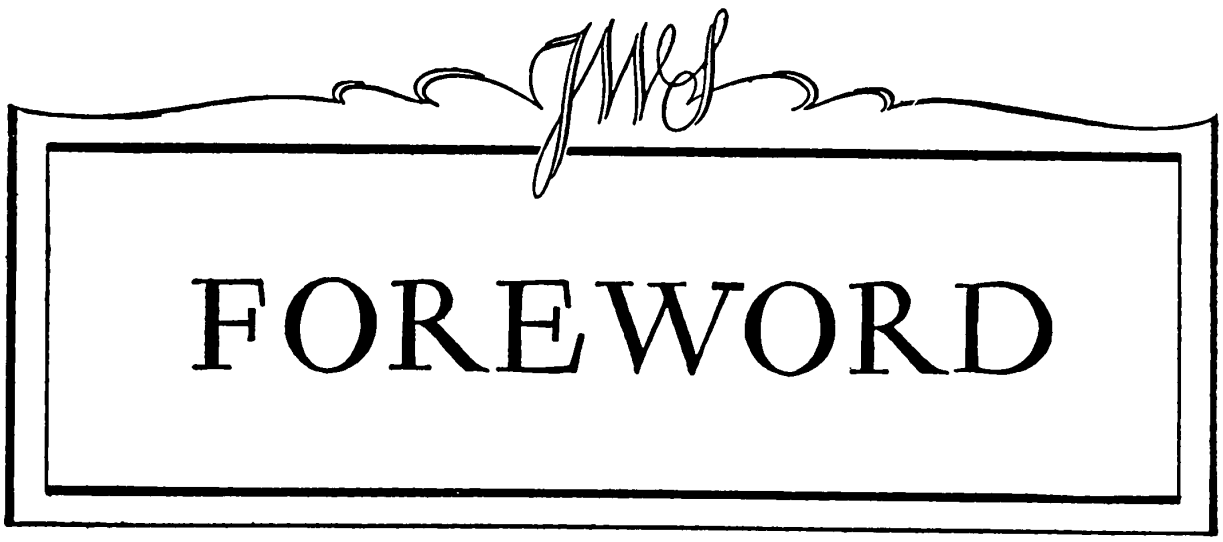


THE Stilwell Papers

By JOSEPH W. STILWELL

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FOREWORD

IT IS with deep feeling and pride that I present these words of my husband, General Joseph W. Stilwell. Because of the many controversies concerning his services in the China-Burma-India theater and his recall in November, 1944, and because he was never allowed to present for himself the true facts of the case, I am giving him this opportunity to speak.

General Stilwell was descended from Nicholas Stillwell (sic) who came to New Amsterdam in 1638. Records and family documents carry the name back to 1456. Among those Stilwells who followed Nicholas, there were many who served this country as soldiers, so it was perhaps natural that my husband chose a military career.

General Stilwell's army life began in 1900, when he entered the United States Military Academy at the age of seventeen. After his graduation in 1904, he saw service in the Philippine Islands with the 12th Infantry. Many interesting years followed and during World War I, he became G-2 of the 4th Corps, under General Briant H. Wells. Between the two World Wars, he was stationed in China three times, for a total of ten years.

In 1921, during his first tour of duty in China as an army language student in Peking, he served in Shansi province as construction engineer on a road being built by the American Red Cross for famine relief. In Shansi, he spent months working and living with Chinese laborers and peasants. In 1927, while stationed in Tientsin, he spent several months as an observer with the Chinese armies, then engaged in Civil War. Because of his intense desire for factual information, he moved continuously on foot within the battle areas. During a later assignment as Military Attaché to the American Embassy in Peking, he learned to know Chinese officials and military leaders of the highest rank. During those years of contact with both the common citizens of China and leaders of wealth and position, General Stilwell developed an intimate understanding of the basic and underlying psychology of China.

Few people realize that General Stilwell, throughout the greatest years of his career, was almost blind. The explosion of an ammunition dump, during World War I at Belrupt, caused a severe injury to the left eye. There was a deformity of the pupil and the growth of a cataract of the lens. The vision of this eye was so impaired that he could not distinguish the fingers on a hand at three feet. The vision of the right eye required heavy correction and constant use of glasses. During the trying days in Chungking, as well as during the jungle campaigns in Burma, where lighting facilities were inadequate, it was often necessary to work by candlelight. His indomitable urge to do his job and do it well forced him to strain the remaining eye. His great hope was that it would last long enough to see him through his mission.

General Stilwell's war journals were written so that he might have a true and factual account of those years. They

were put down for his own use. But to me his gallant spirit lives on, encouraging me to bring his journals to publication.

The major problems that confronted General Stilwell during the war are those that essentially confront the representatives of our country in China today. Since a free and great democracy can function successfully only upon the basis of true information, it is my hope that these journals will bring a clearer understanding of the problems America faces in China. We shall then stand much closer to a careful and proper solution.

Winifred A. Stilwell

Chinese soldier. To me the Chinese soldier best exemplifies the greatness of the Chinese people—their indomitable spirit, their uncomplaining loyalty, their honesty of purpose, their steadfast perseverance. He endures untold privations without a whimper, he follows wherever he is led, without question or hesitation, and it never occurs to his simple and straightforward mind that he is doing anything heroic. He asks for little, and always stands ready to give all. I feel it is a great honor, as a representative of the U.S. Army, to salute here today, the Chinese soldier.

JULY 8 Have been bombing Chiang K'ai-shek with memos on Kunming and reorganization and estimates, etc. He doesn't take the trouble to reply. Madame expects me to push all this stuff at him, but there seems to be no obligation on his part to even mention it. It is passed to the smart boys in the Chün ling pu [Bureau of Military Operations], of course, and I can imagine what they do with it. The "three demands" missed fire and the President's answer was very quiet and dignified. Maybe there will be a changed attitude in the U.S. If so, maybe I can force Chiang K'ai-shek's hand, and work in a scheme of reorganization and training.

JULY 10 Russki rumor: Yuan Liang [12] and party here with peace terms. Also a Jap, Kuroda: Chinese to go back to Nanking [the prewar capital of China]. Wang Ching-wei [13] to set up in north China. Japs keep Canton, Hangchow, Shanghai.

Possibilities. Sympathy here for the Nazis. Same type of government, same outlook, same gangsterism. The howl of "Beat Japan First" has two possible explanations—one, that if it is done, that lets China coast in without effort on her part: and two, that diversion of American effort to the Pa-

cific would relieve Germany of worry about a second front, and perhaps enable her to get a decision from Russia. Chiang K'ai-shek would prefer to see Germany win than to end up with a powerful Russia at his door, backing up the Eighteenth Army Group [the Chinese Communist Army]. Which, by the way, has spread pretty well all over North China.

Well, well. This has angles. Our fool publicity "heroic resistance—five years' struggle" etc., etc. have set it up for Chiang K'ai-shek—he can say to us "Sorry, we've reached the limit: without help we can't go on." Accept the [Jap] offer and coast [along], telling us sub rosa he was just bowing to necessity.[14] Then, if we win, as he expects, he'll have it all handed to him. If we lose, he has salvaged something, although the Japs couldn't be trusted not to clean him up when they get through with the Russians. However, it would be harder to clean him up from the new position than from the present one. Chiang K'ai-shek can't get the material he needs anyway, so what's the difference till the war is over.

He risks two important things: (1) The definite loss of all supplies he was counting on from the U.S. and the big money that would be withdrawn and (2) the loss of the sympathy of the American people, who are with him while

[12] A Chinese politician of some fame in North China. He was a former mayor of Peking, and, during the war, reportedly aided the Japanese.
[13] The Chinese puppet installed by the Japanese as head of their satellite government in Central China.
[14] For more about the relations between the Japanese and Chiang K'ai-shek in the course of the war, see "Nazi-Soviet Relations 1939-1941" published by the U. S. State Department. Matsuoka, Japan's minister of Foreign Relations, told the Germans of his progress with Chiang K'ai-shek in the spring of 1941. "Matsuoka agreed with these ideas and cited the situation in China as an example. Chiang K'ai-shek, with whom he was in personal touch, who knew him and trusted him, was greatly alarmed as to the further increase of the influence of the Red Army in China."

he fights, but who won't back a quitter. These factors seem to outweigh all other considerations.

Gauss is positive they do. He has had assurances from highly placed officials that any talk of peace terms is bull and he snorts at the idea. I believe he is right and that they are trying to pull our leg again.

JULY 10, THE MANURE PILE: LETTER TO MRS. STILWELL. This is the most dreary type of maneuvering I've ever done, trying to guide and influence a stubborn, ignorant, prejudiced, conceited despot who never hears the truth except from me and finds it hard to believe. I'm supposed to buck the inertia of this country all by myself and keep everything lovely by promise and persuasion. What a job. I'm exhausting the possibilities one by one and when I get to the bottom of the bucket, I'll tell 'em. Then they'll HAVE to do something.

JULY 15 Interpreters [for] Ramgarh ready. Artillery officers [for training] held up in War Ministry.

JULY 16 No answer from Chiang K'ai-shek to any of my memos sent during last month. No answer on request to see him, a week ago. Only action was appointing me commanding general of Chinese troops in India. Maybe they are ignoring me because I wouldn't get behind the ultimatum.

JULY 18 Long radio from Marshall. Chiang K'ai-shek wired T. V. Soong that I had "wired the American staff of CNAC to refuse transfer of two transport planes." A lie. Also that "Chiang K'ai-shek had to beg me for Lend-Lease materials already delivered to China." Another lie. (Don't I always ask *him*?) Some bastard is always trying to discredit me. Chiang K'ai-shek went on with a long drool about

CONFERENCE ON POLICY IN CHINA

December 6, 1943, at Alexander Kirk's home, Cairo. After Teheran.

Present: Roosevelt, H.H. [Harry Hopkins], J.W.S. [Joseph W. Stilwell], and ——[3]

F.D.R. Well, Joe, what do you think of the bad news?

J.W.S. I haven't heard yet how bad it is.

F.D.R. We're in an impasse. I've been stubborn as a mule for four days but we can't get anywhere, and it won't do for a conference to end that way. The British just won't do the operation, and I can't get them to agree to it.

J.W.S. I am interested to know how this affects our policy in China.

F.D.R. Well, now, we've been friends with China for a gr-e-e-at many years. I ascribe a large part of this feeling to the missionaries. You know *I* have a China history. My grandfather went out there, to Swatow and Canton, in 1829, and even went up to Hankow. He did what was every American's ambition in those days—he made a million dollars, and when he came back he put it into western railroads. And in eight years he lost every dollar. Ha! Ha! Ha! Then in 1856 he went out again and *stayed there all through the Civil War,* and made another million. This time he put it into coal mines, and they didn't pay a dividend until two years after he died. Ha! Ha! Ha!

J.W.S. I take it that it is our policy to build China up.

F.D.R. Yes. Yes. Build her up. After this war there will be a great need of our help. They will want loans. Madame Chiang and the G-mo wanted to get a loan

[3] Name of the fourth American deleted.

now of a billion dollars, but I told them it would be difficult to get Congress to agree to it. Now, I'm not a financial expert (!!) but I have a plan to take fifty or a hundred million dollars and buy up Chinese paper dollars on the black market. It wouldn't take much. (!!) When the Chinese found out that these notes were being bought up, they would tend to hold them and the rate would come down. We might beat the inflation that way. And I'd share the profit with the Chinese government—I'd put the notes in escrow and when they were needed I'd sell them to the Chinese for what I paid for them.

—— The effect on the Chinese of failing to reopen communications—

F.D.R. Yes. Yes. How long do you think Chiang can last?

J.W.S. The situation is serious and a repetition of last May's attack might overturn him.

F.D.R. Well, then we should look for some other man or group of men, to carry on.

J.W.S. They would probably be looking for us.

F.D.R. Yes, they would come to us. They really like us and just between ourselves, they *don't* like the British. Now, we haven't the same aims as the British out there. For instance, Hongkong. Now, I have a plan to make Hongkong a free port: free to the commerce of all nations—of the whole world! But let's raise the Chinese flag there first, and then Chiang can the next day make a grand gesture and make it a free port. That's the way to handle that! Same way in Dairen! I'm sure that Chiang would be willing to make that a free port, and goods could come through Siberia—in bond—without customs examinations.

—— What in your opinion caused the noble attitude of the Russians in allowing China to have Manchuria?

F.D.R. Well, I think they consider they've got enough as it is. You can put a hundred million more people into Siberia. Stalin doesn't want any more ground. He's got enough. He agreed with me about Korea and Indo-China. We should set up commissions to take charge of those countries for twenty-five years or so, till we get them on their feet. Just like the Philippines. I asked Chiang point-blank if he wanted Indo-China, and he said, "Under no circumstances!" Just like that—"Under no circumstances."

J.W.S. Chiang will have trouble explaining to his people the Allied failure to open Burma.

F.D.R. Yes. Yes. But if we don't put on this operation, we can put more tonnage over the Hump. Yes, we can get more freight into China that way.

H.H. Is this CNAC a Pan American subsidiary?

J.W.S. Forty-nine per cent is American, fifty-one per cent is Chinese.

F.D.R. Well, that's all right. The Chinese can run their airline *inside of China*. I have no objection to that. Now, I would agree to the British, after the war, running passenger planes for Australia from England to New York, letting off passengers for New York, taking on passengers for *Australia*, and then flying to San Francisco, letting off passengers from England, and taking on passengers for Australia. But not to take passengers on at New York and letting them off at San Francisco. Oh, no. No, sir.

J.W.S. We need guidance on political policy on China.

F.D.R. Yes. As I was saying, the Chinese will want a lot of help from us—a *lot* of it. Why, K'ung one time asked

me for a loan of fifty million dollars for developing transportation and I said to him, "Mr. K'ung, that's a *lot* of money!" Then I said to him, "What are you going to use this money for?" and he said, "Construction materials," and he said, to try and influence me, "If we get this loan, we'll buy those materials right here in the United States." And I came right back at him and said, "Mr. K'ung, in your country you have construction materials already. You have cement, you have sand, you have rock—you have all those materials." Then he said, "Yes, but we need technical help—engineers and other technicians. We would pay a good engineer $100,000 a year, and give him a house and twenty servants." And I said, "Mr. K'ung, when I was governor of New York State, I had a superintendent of highway construction named Green—(ever know Green?)—and he was paid $15,000. And he was the best road engineer I ever saw. But he's dead. But don't pay $100,000—pay $15,000—no house, no servants. You don't want to pay $100,000. Why, there are any number of good engineers in the Army—not the regular service, men from civil life—and you can get them for $8,000. They can do that kind of work. But no exploitation."

STOOGE The Prime Minister is here.

F.D.R. Well, now, there you are and remember, YOU'RE AMBASSADORS! Ha! Ha! Ha! Yes, sir, you're my Ambassadors.

End of Conference
Draw your own conclusions.

H.H. What do you think would be a good religion in Japan?

Chungking, flying toward the Burma border where combat troops awaited his command. With these he planned to drive into Burma as deeply as possible, striking for the Chinese border.

[UNDATED] Return from Cairo. Graduation exercises at [Chinese] Military Academy. As Peanut mounted rostrum band leader counted 1-2-3, but unfortunately band sounded off at 2. Peanut was furious, stopped band, bawled out leader: "Either start playing [on 1] or start on 3. Don't start on 2!" Then a speaker pulled his notes out of his pants pocket. This infuriated Peanut. He bawled him out, and told him that *tsai wai kuo* [in foreign countries] you could put a handkerchief in your pants pockets but not papers. Papers go in lower coat pockets, and, if secret, in upper coat pockets. Then someone stumbled on procedure and Peanut went wild, screaming that he ought to be shot . . . *Ch'iang pi* [shoot him] and repeating it at the top of his voice.

DECEMBER 15 The Reds are no longer afraid [of Chiang K'ai-shek]. The Central Government men desert to them. One whole company deserted and the Reds sent the rifles back. "We can't force the men to return, but here are the rifles." More troops moved up to contain the Reds, but their propaganda is working. They feel that Chiang K'ai-shek's position is weak.

CONFERENCE WITH PEANUT Put it to him as to possible results of reneging on Burma operation. He has a trick solution: accept *both* of the plans offered by President:[6] i.e., get ready [for Burma offensive] and be in position and then "when spring comes" decide if "conditions are favorable." If so, fight. If not, wait till November [1944]. Told him it was necessary to decide *now*, so troop moves could start. Asked him who would decide the case and he said he would!

In other words, no fight. The little bastard never intended to.

[He] keeps coming back to the amphibious operation,[7] promised by President. Told him present plan better than old one, except for size of amphibious operation. No soap. This amphibious operation is just "no good." We ought to attack Moulmein and "cut off the rear." Says we mustn't risk being defeated in Burma. The effect on the Chinese people would be too serious. The little hypocrite. Even at expense of remaining cut off—still he won't risk defeat. Of course, next November the same argument will be just as weighty.

May did her best. She realizes the implications and it drives her nuts. Wants a meeting with K'ung tomorrow to dope out something, but I can see she is pretty low and hasn't much hope of changing the little bastard over.

DECEMBER 16 Saw May and Ella. They're close to nervous prostration. Can't sleep. May said she *prayed* with him [Chiang] last night. Told me she'd done "everything except murder him." Ella says when he's tired he takes refuge in being "noble." We doped out what to do and decided on asking F.D.R. to send him a radio.. "Expect you to lend same wholehearted co-op that the British gave Eisenhower."

Session with ———, in which I gave him some dope to feed the Peanut. Asked him how come they had 300 divisions and couldn't fill up 10 [full strength divisions]. He said they were "useless." Imagine that.

Session with Ho Ying-ch'in.[8] His usual line of crap. "U.S.

[6] Offered by Roosevelt at Cairo, see page 255.

[7] For attack on Japanese in southern Burma.

[8] At this time, Stilwell was trying to place U.S. Army officers with front-line divisions of the Chinese Armies to observe their use of American equipment and instruct them. The Chinese were for a long while reluctant to let Americans live with their troops.

instructors can't live with Chinese troops—they wouldn't be comfortable. We can't *chao tai* [accommodate them] properly," etc., etc. Told him I had done so[9] often and my people would, too. [He said] the Russians [previous Russian observers] had complained; it was very unpleasant. Told him we wouldn't and that we'd relieve the kickers. He pulled some stuff about training programs and time limits and crap, and I told him the G-mo said we were welcome in all units, for indefinite stay. He said of course if I did not trust the Chinese officers we could send checkers to watch the motor movement. I told him that wasn't the reason: U.S. [money] was being spent and I was responsible for it and had to report. We got him on every count, and had him running so much that McCammon couldn't look at him toward the end.

(4:00 p.m.) Conference with the Peanut. More history made. When he says anything, it's so: i.e., "There are eight Jap divisions in Burma." He just says it, so it must be so. If I say everybody agrees that there are five divisions, he just says "No, there are eight." Again flatly—"We have only one chance in a hundred of winning." Again—"We have even less chance of winning now than we had in 1942!" Good God. And if I mention air, artillery, tanks, 200,000 Chinese, and 180,000 British he still sticks to it.

He "reasons" that "we have a better chance to win if we take the defensive and let the Japs attack." I asked him where we would be if the U.S. had adopted that attitude two years ago. No answer. He has an idea that the British won't fight, and that he will sit on his ass till the Americans come and save him. "We'll get ready and tell Mountbatten to go ahead with his plans—and then, if everything is favorable, we'll fight. We must wait for the opportune time."

Good God. He's so ignorant of military matters that he thinks he can get an offensive started at the word "Go." Very nice guarantee of co-operation for the British to lean on.

"Let the British go ahead and attack Akyab." [10] I told him *they* would naturally expect *him* to do something to take pressure off of them, just as *he* is insisting in treble notes that *they* attack and take pressure off him. Oh, no, that's different. "We must have three to one to beat the Japs." I tell him we have more than three to one—in Yünnan we have fourteen divisions against one and a third. "Oh, no, they have several divisions there." Nothing is possible without a big amphibious operation. He doesn't know what a big amphibious operation is, but unfortunately Mountbatten was honest about it. So now that it is on a reduced scale, he screams. It is fatal to promise anything.

Another unfortunate thing was the President's message, giving him a choice of jumping off [in Burma] in March, or waiting till November, and promising "heavy amphibious operations" then. *That* will be insisted on now. F.D.R. should have insisted on his co-operating as planned, under pain of cutting off all supplies. Now he believes he can go just as far as he likes and the U.S. will cringe and take it. He's not going to fight at any time, regardless of what he says.

The pay-off is that I can go ahead and fight with the Ledo force. He is afraid that even concerted attack by all available forces has only one chance in a hundred and yet he'll sit back and let a small force take on the Japs alone. Madame is discouraged, disgusted, and a little dismayed. She can't do a thing with him.

[9] Lived with Chinese troops in the field.
[10] A port in southwestern Burma.

JANUARY 12 Cleveland back with bad news. Generalissimo now demands [before committing Yoke force] amphibious operations on Andaman Islands plus . . . plus . . . plus cutting of communications between Bhamo and Lashio. No replacements in sight. We are out on a limb.

LETTER TO MRS. STILWELL We eat straight rations or Chinese chow and we live where we have to and the trails are tough, and we get wet and muddy, but we sleep soundly and the food tastes good because we are usually hungry. The principal hazard is being hit on the head by a bag of rice dumped out of a plane. Once in a while the Japs' patrols get ambitious but they have pulled in their horns lately and the trails to the rear are quite safe. Progress is slow; the jungle is everywhere and very nearly impenetrable. Yesterday, on a cut trail I took 3½ hours to do 3 miles, tripping and cursing at every step. It takes a long time to even locate the Japs, and a lot more to dig them out. We are in tiger and elephant country although I haven't seen any yet. Some of the men have and I've seen droppings and tracks. When an elephant leaves his card in the trail, it takes a pole vaulter to climb over it. I expect to see Tarzan any day now. The jungle is full of his long swinging vines. This experience is different from the last time. Now we have aviation and ammunition and artillery and a certain amount of training, so we don't have to take it on the nose as we used to, with no chance of answering. The Chinese soldier is doing his stuff, as I knew he would if he had half a chance. It's only the higher-ups who are weak and they are still pretty terrible. The Americans are all doing a good job and they all enjoy the life. If I could just have a couple of U.S. divisions. But the Brain Trust won't turn them over, so I've got to go on struggling with my shoestring. The Glamour Boy [Mountbatten] is just

about that. He doesn't wear well and I begin to wonder if he knows his stuff. Enormous staff, endless walla-walla, but damn little fighting. And of course the Peanut is unchanged. The jungle is a refuge from them both and I am leaving the shoveling of manure to a couple of my boys.

JANUARY 13 Long talk with Sun. Again impressed on him extreme importance of this operation and serious consequences of failure. He protests he means business and will take Taipha.

JANUARY 21 To Ningam, arrived at 11:00. Saw Brown [Colonel Rothwell Brown, tank commander] at Shingbwiyan. 87 tanks in, remainder in [from Ledo] today. One lost. Fine job [over road] under terrible conditions, Brown says worse than anything he can imagine. Everybody performed. One Chinese killed—tried to jump out of tank. Gave them three days to rest and refit. P.m. doped out plan of advance to south.

JANUARY 28 Off [at] 7:00 down the river, 9:00 at boathead. 9:30 to 12:00 getting to [front]. Went over Jap position; it was too small and the mortars gave them hell. Not well dug in, in spite of occupation from January 19 to January 24. Thompson claims probably 325 dead Japs. They were all over the place with heads and feet sticking out, rather hurried burial; plenty in the river. They ran their guns in the river.

JANUARY 30 [Reached] Delhi at 7:30. Long talk with Sultan and Ferris on the situation here. The Limeys are welching.

JANUARY 31, DELHI Office. 10:00 a.m. to the big walla-walla [conference]. The Limeys take me more seriously now. But they won't fight if they can help it. Blew off my